

Education Indicator

EDUCATION AND LEARNING OUTCOMES

School leavers with NCEA Level 1 or above

In 2024, 84% of school leavers achieved NCEA Level 1 or above and 87% met NCEA Level 1 literacy and numeracy requirements.

Indicator description

Percentage of school leavers with at least an NCEA Level 1 qualification or equivalent.¹

Why attaining NCEA Level 1 is important

The National Certificate of Educational Achievement Level 1 (NCEA Level 1) is the first stage of upper secondary education and serves as a foundation for further study and/or employment. NCEA Level 1, as with all levels of NCEA, encompasses a wide range of learning. Students can attain credits through internal and external assessment, and they can accumulate these credits both within and across years.

NCEA Level 1 is an optional level for schools that wish to continue to use this qualification, with some schools adopting alternative approaches to focus on higher levels of NCEA to best meet the needs of their students. Many students value NCEA Level 1, however, as it introduces them to the format of NCEA assessment and prepares them for their next steps. For around 10% of New Zealand students, NCEA Level 1 will be their highest schooling qualification.

The attainment of an upper secondary school qualification is linked to labour force status and incomes. Every year around 60,000 young people leave school and face choices about what to do next. Not being in employment, further education, or training (NEET) affects around 30% of school leavers in the first year after they finish school, including almost 70% of leavers without a qualification and almost 50% of leavers with a Level 1 qualification.² In 2022, New Zealanders without NCEA Level 2 earned 8% less than those with an upper secondary education, compared with the OECD average of 18% less (OECD, 2024).

¹ Equivalent attainment includes attainment of NCEA Level 1 standard from assessments outside the New Zealand Qualifications Framework. Examples of alternative assessments are: International Baccalaureate, Cambridge International exams and Accelerated Christian Education.

² Data covers school leavers from 2010-2020 inclusive. Results are derived from the Integrated Data Infrastructure (IDI) managed by Stats NZ and are not official statistics. For more information, please visit <https://www.stats.govt.nz/integrated-data/>

How are we going

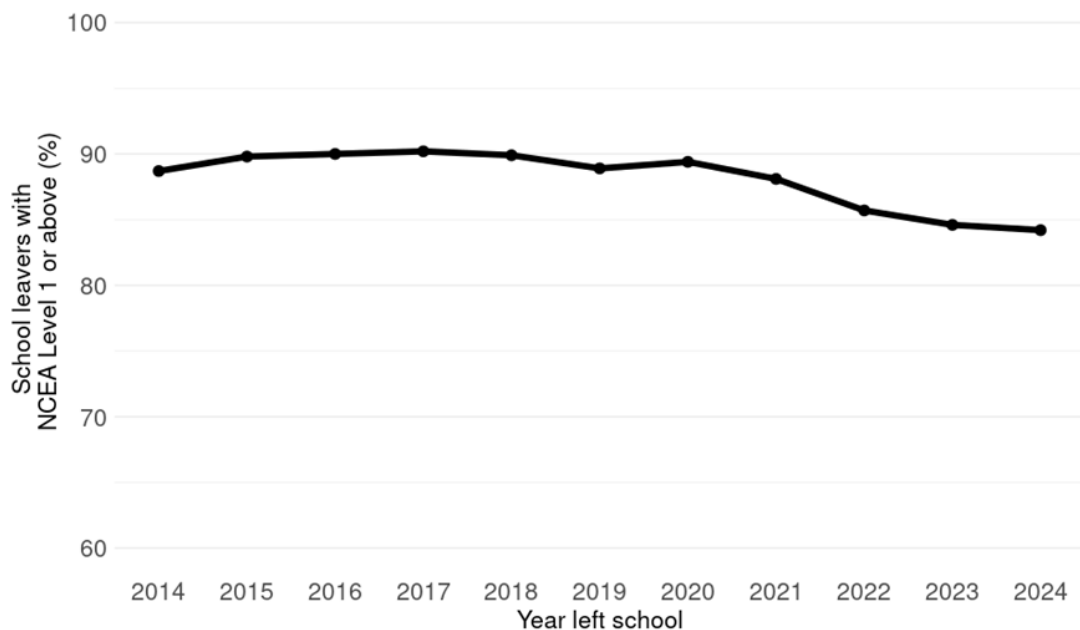
In 2024, 84.2% (56,767) of school leavers attained NCEA Level 1 or above, a decrease of 0.4 percentage points (84.6% in 2023). Attainment of NCEA Level 1 peaked in 2017 at 90.2% and has decreased by 6.0 percentage points since then. This is the lowest attainment rate since 2014 (see Figure 1).

In 2024, female school leavers were more likely to attain NCEA Level 1 or above (85.4%) than their male peers (83.1%).

Asian school leavers had the highest attainment rate for NCEA Level 1 or above (91.9%), followed by European/Pākehā (86.1%), Pacific (81.4%), and then Māori (72.3%).

Schools where learners had fewer barriers to achievement had higher attainment rates. In 2024, 96.1% of leavers from schools where learners had the fewest barriers attained NCEA Level 1 or above compared to 71.0% of leavers from schools where learners had the most barriers.

Figure 1 The attainment rate for NCEA Level 1 or above decreased in 2024



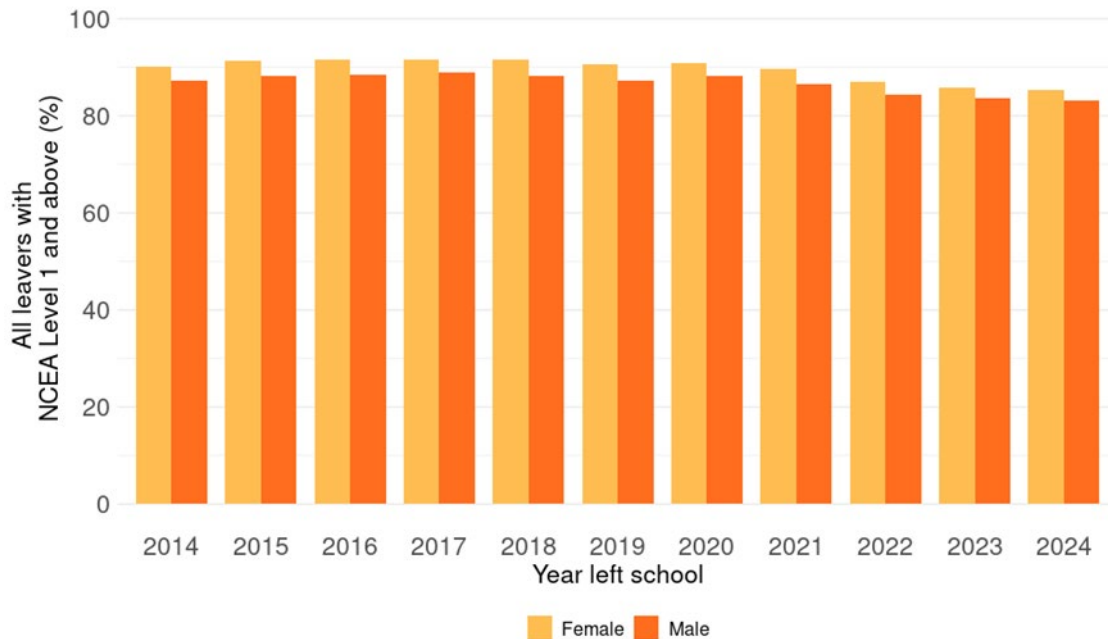
Gender

Since 2014, NCEA Level 1 or above attainment has been higher for female school leavers, as shown in Figure 2.

In 2024, 85.4% of female leavers attained NCEA Level 1 or above compared to 83.1% of male leavers. This was a decrease of 0.3 percentage points for female leavers and a decrease of 0.5 percentage points for male leavers since 2023. This has increased the gender gap from 2.1 percentage points in 2023 to 2.3 percentage points in 2024.



Figure 2: Since 2014 the attainment rates for female leavers have been higher than the attainment rates for male leavers



Socioeconomic barriers³

At a system level, schools where students experience more socioeconomic barriers to achievement have lower NCEA Level 1 or above attainment rates and a higher variability of attainment rates within the School Equity Index Bands. This indicates there is an association between the attainment of NCEA Level 1 or above and socioeconomic barriers.

In 2024, schools with the fewest barriers to achievement had an NCEA Level 1 attainment rate of 96.3%, and those with the most barriers to achievement had an attainment rate of 72.3%.

Figure 3 shows the distribution of NCEA Level 1 or above attainment rates for school leavers in 2024 by schools within each School Equity Index Band. There was variation in the percentage of school leavers attaining NCEA Level 1 or above among schools within each band. This variation from the average increased with barriers to achievement. Schools with the fewest barriers to achievement had less school-to-school variation from the average, as shown by the dots that are scattered closer to the band average. Schools with more barriers to achievement had higher between-school variations in attainment rates. Within each band, there were schools that had higher attainment rates while others had disproportionately low attainment rates.

³ For more information about the equity index see the section at the end of this indicator report.



Figure 3: The proportion of school leavers with NCEA Level 1 or above varied between schools within each School Equity Index Band

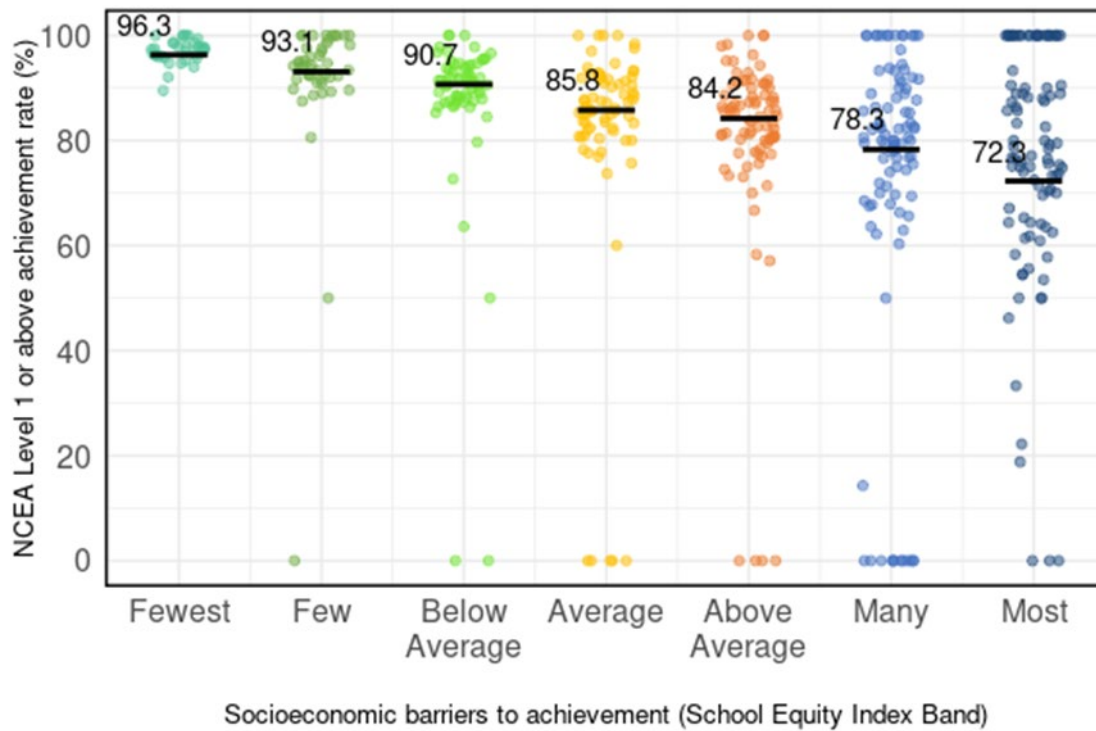
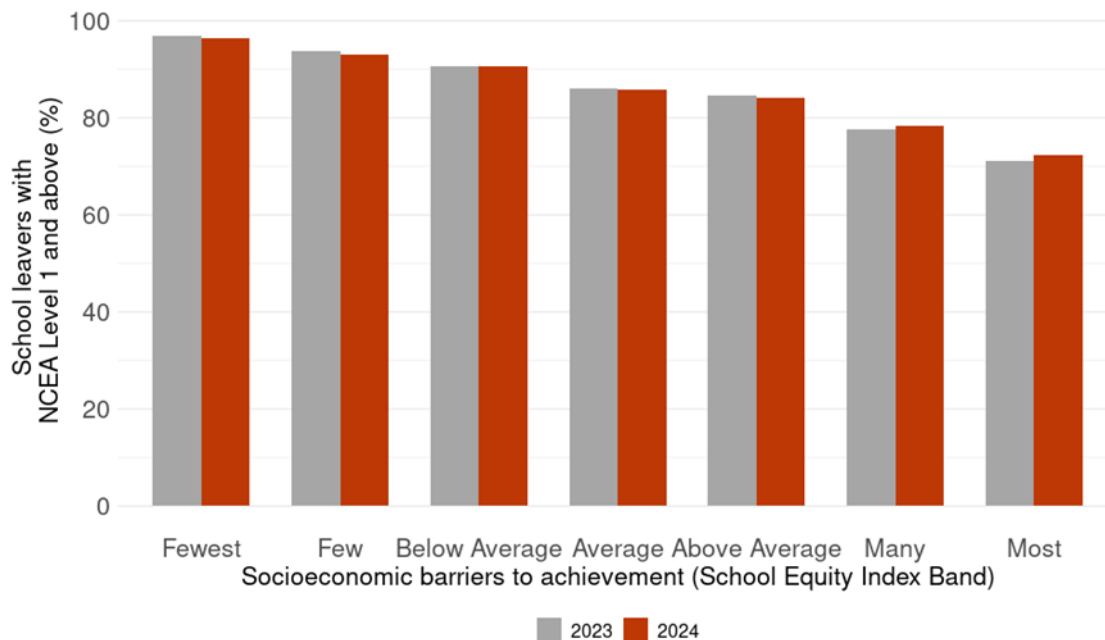


Figure 4: The proportion of school leavers attaining NCEA Level 1 or above by School Equity Index Band, 2023-2024



Compared to 2023, in 2024 a higher proportion of school leavers left school with NCEA Level 1 or above from schools where learners had many (77.3% in 2024 compared to 76.8% in 2023) or the most (71.0% in 2024 compared to 69.7% in 2023) barriers to achievement as shown in Figure 4. In schools with the fewest or few barriers to achievement, the proportion of school leavers who attained NCEA Level 1 or above decreased in 2024 (by 0.6 and 0.9 percentage points respectively). NCEA Level 1 attainment rates were unchanged from 2023 to 2024 for schools with average barriers to achievement.

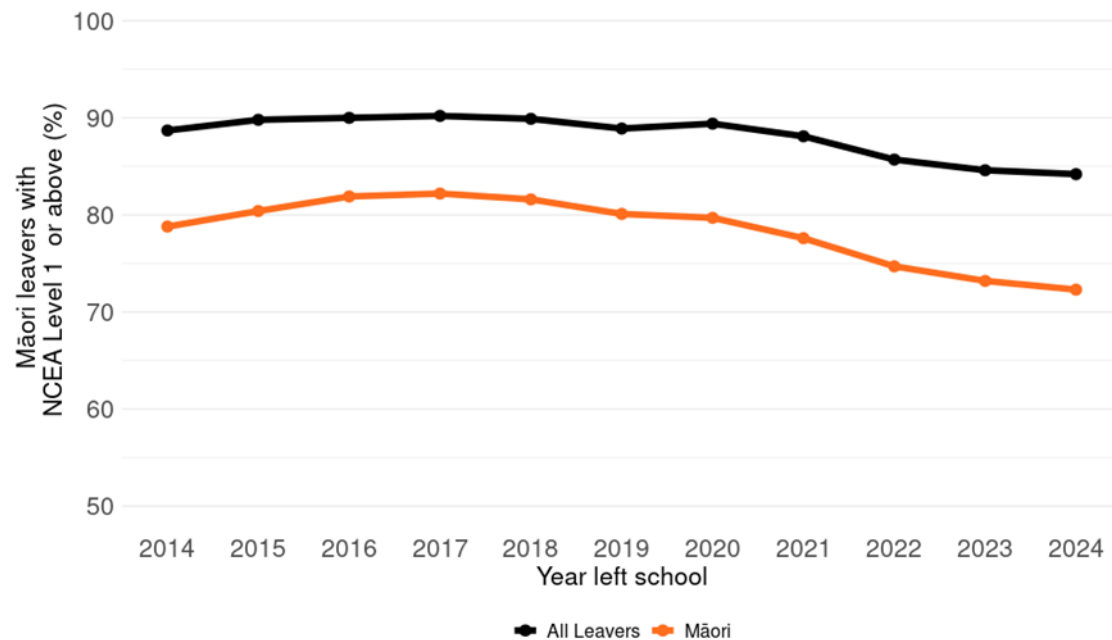
Ethnicity⁴

Compared to 2023, the proportion of school leavers attaining NCEA Level 1 or above in 2024 was lower across all ethnic groupings, except for Pacific school leavers where the attainment rate remained unchanged.

Māori school leavers

In 2024, 12,194 Māori school leavers (72.3%) attained NCEA Level 1 or above, as shown in Figure 5. This was the lowest proportion since 2014. Between 2017 (peak attainment for Māori school leavers) and 2024, the attainment rate for NCEA Level 1 decreased by 9.8 percentage points. Between 2019 (the most recent year prior to Covid-19) and 2024, the attainment rate decreased by 7.8 percentage points. The gap in NCEA Level 1 attainment rates between Māori school leavers and all school leavers increased in 2024 to 11.9 percentage points, up 0.5 percentage points from 2023. This was the largest gap since 2014, and 3.8 percentage points more than in 2017 when the gap was smallest.

Figure 5: Māori school leavers' attainment of NCEA Level 1 or above decreased in 2024

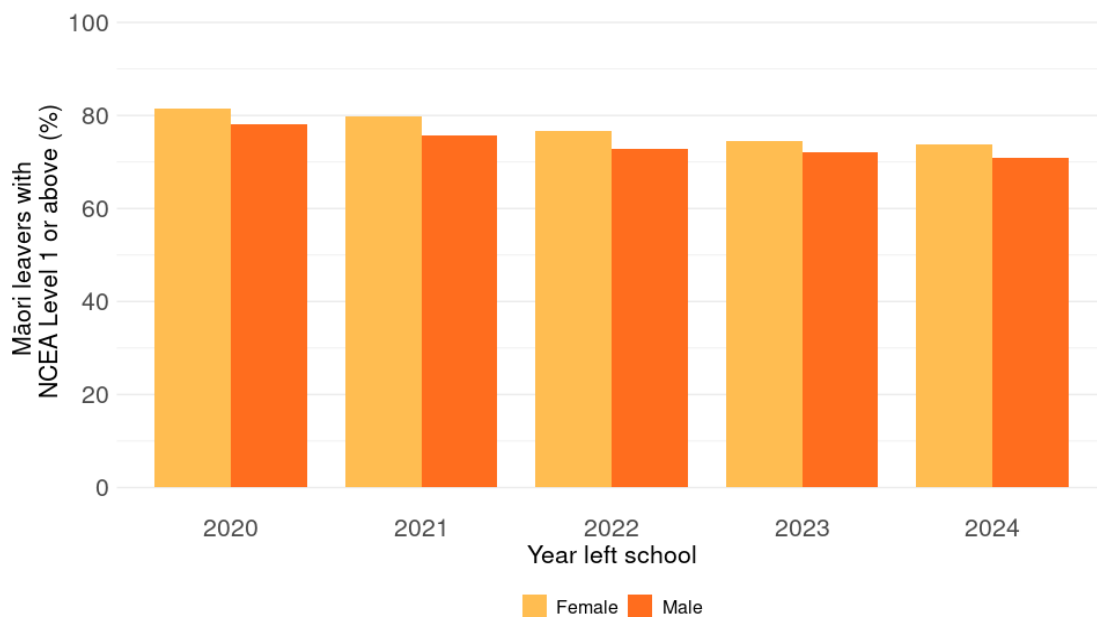


⁴ Total response ethnicity counts students who identify with more than one ethnic group in each of these ethnic groups. For the New Zealand total, individuals are counted only once.



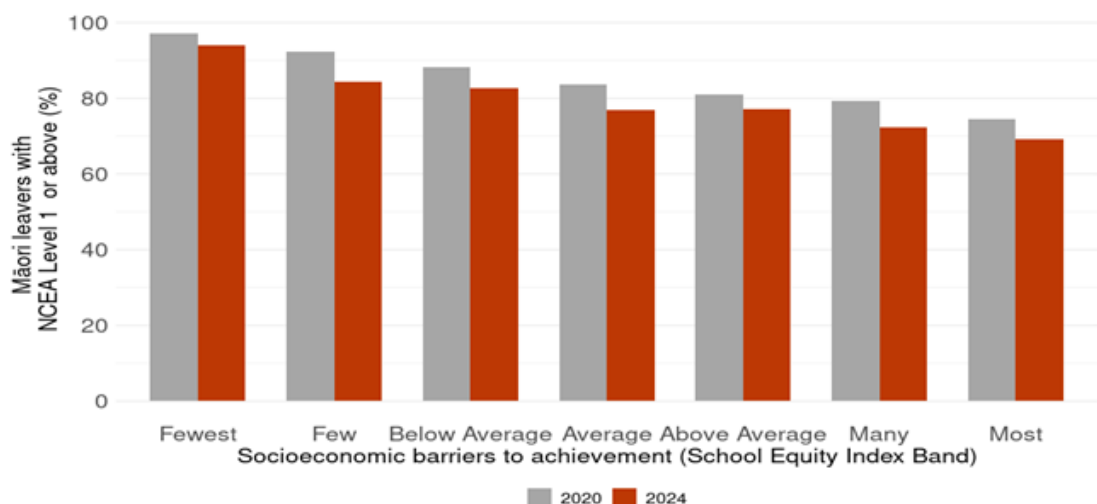
In 2024, 73.7 % of Māori female school leavers attained NCEA Level 1 or above compared to 70.9% of Māori male school leavers; the lowest rates for both Māori females and males since 2014. Since 2020, Māori female school leavers had higher NCEA Level 1 or above attainment rates compared to Māori male leavers as shown in Figure 6. The gap in NCEA Level 1 attainment rates between females and males decreased from a peak of 5.5 percentage points in 2019, to 3.5 percentage points in 2020, and 2.8 percentage points in 2024.

Figure 6: Māori female school leavers were more likely to attain NCEA Level 1 or above



Māori school leavers from schools with fewer barriers to achievement were more likely to attain NCEA Level 1 or above. In 2024, 94.1% of Māori leavers from schools with the fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 1 compared to 69.3% of Māori leavers from schools with the most barriers to achievement. The NCEA Level 1 or above attainment rates declined in 2024 compared to 2020 as shown in Figure 7. Schools with few barriers to achievement had the highest decline in attainment rates from 92.3% in 2020 to 84.3% in 2024.

Figure 7: The proportion of Māori school leavers with NCEA Level 1 or above has decreased in all School Equity Index Bands since 2020



Māori and language of learning⁵

Māori predominantly learning in te reo Māori

Of the 16,861 ākonga Māori who left school in 2024, 5% (835 Māori school leavers) were predominantly learning in te reo Māori, an increase of 74.7% since 2014 (478 Māori school leavers in 2014).

Note, that when looking at statistics based on small populations such as the small number of school leavers learning in te reo Māori, a small change in numbers can result in a relatively large change in the proportions and therefore relatively large fluctuations from year to year.

In 2024, 87.9% of Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori attained NCEA Level 1 or above, up 3.8 percentage points from 2023.

The gap in NCEA Level 1 attainment rates between Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori and all school leavers increased to 3.7 percentage points in 2024 (87.9% and 84.2% respectively). In the last 10 years the difference has been as large as 4.3 percentage points (in 2017) and as low as 0.5 percentage points (in 2023). In 2024, this gap was the result of a higher increase in attainment rates for Māori leavers predominantly learning in te reo compared to the rate for all leavers, unlike in previous years (see Figure 8).

Māori predominantly learning in English

The NCEA Level 1 or above attainment rate for Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in English was 71.5%, down 1.1 percentage points from 2023.

The gap in NCEA Level 1 attainment rates between Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in English and all school leavers increased to 12.7 percentage points in 2024 from 12.0 percentage points in 2023. This was the largest gap since 2014.

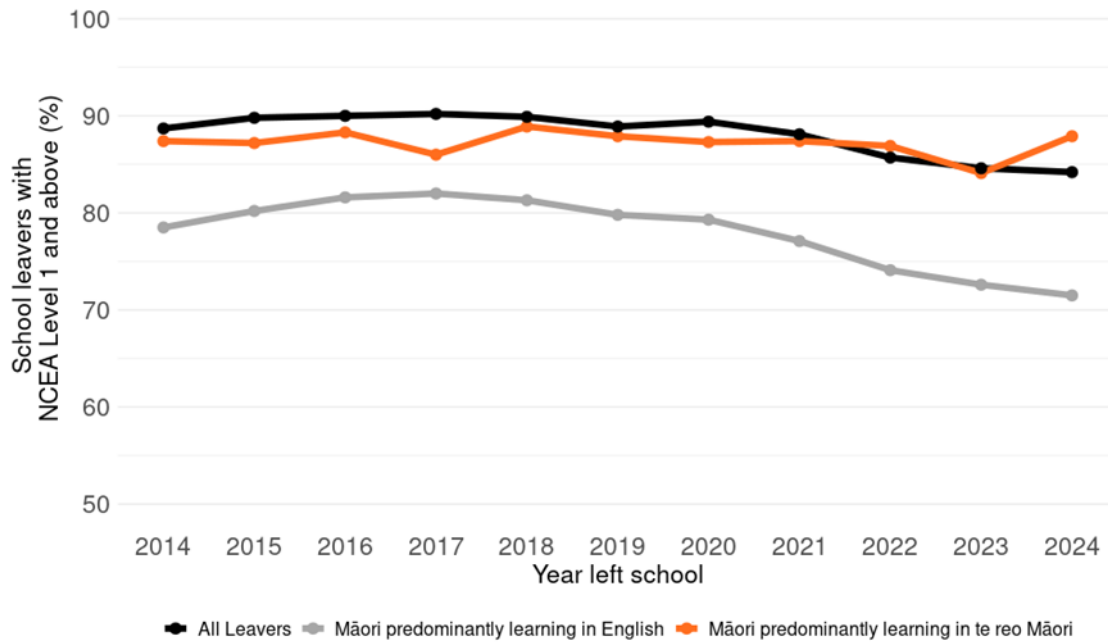
Figure 8 also shows that the attainment of NCEA Level 1 or above for school leavers predominantly learning in te reo Māori was comparable to all leavers' attainment across 2014- 2024. In contrast, Māori school leavers predominantly learning in English consistently had lower attainment rates over the same period.

In 2024, Māori school leavers predominantly learning in te reo Māori outperformed the national average as well as Māori leavers learning predominantly in English. This is consistent with the findings by Smith et. al (2020) that connection with identity, language and culture has large effects on NCEA outcomes for ākonga Māori as shown by higher attainment for ākonga Māori learning in te reo Māori.

⁵ The predominant language of learning is the one that school leavers are learning in at least 51% of the time.



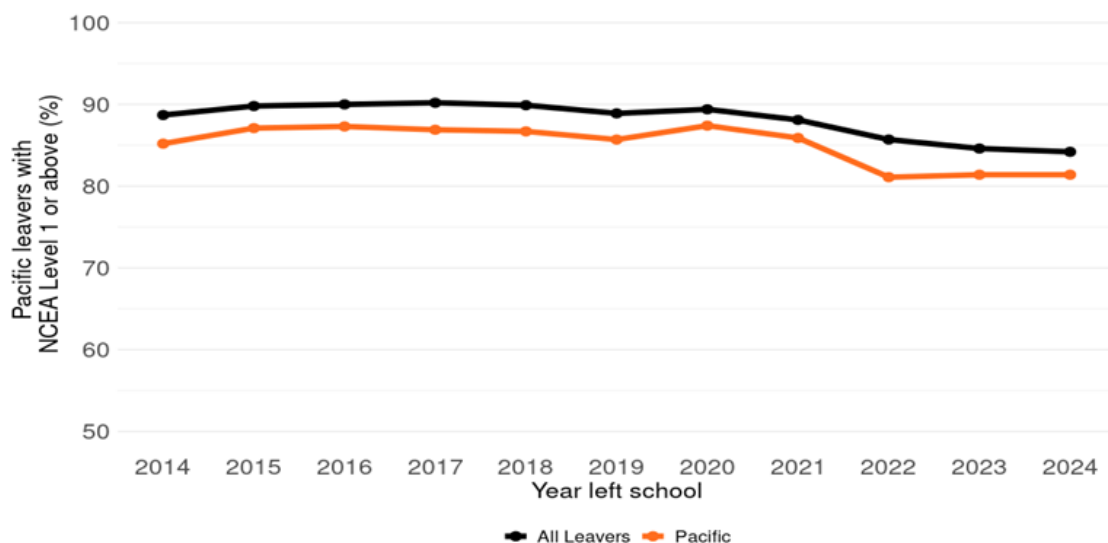
Figure 8: A higher proportion of Māori school leavers predominantly learning in te reo Māori attained NCEA Level 1 or above



Pacific school leavers

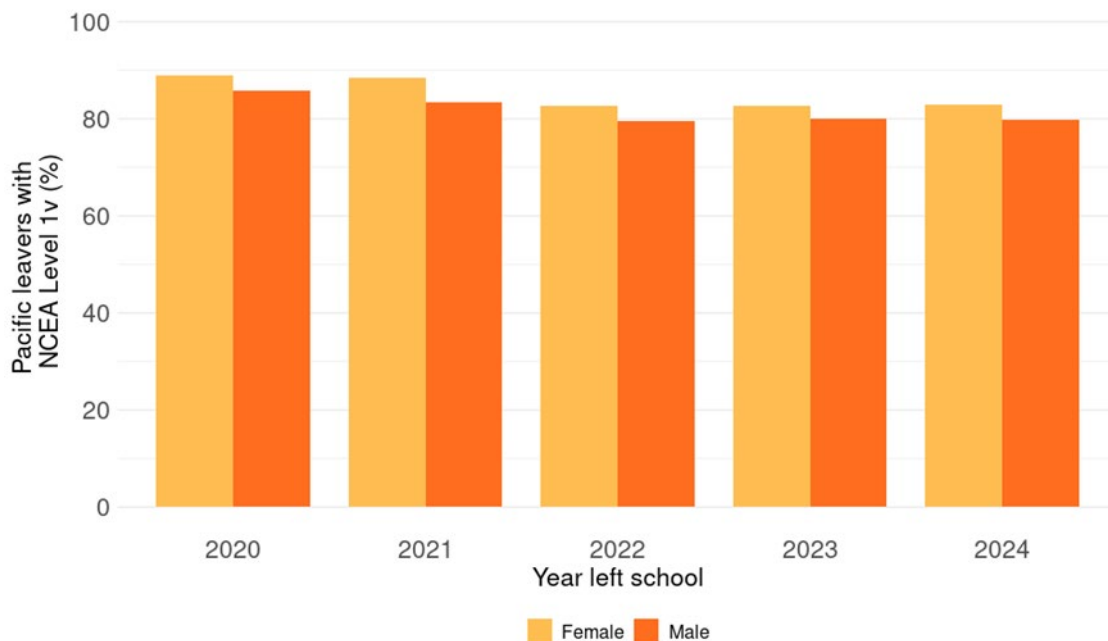
In 2024, 7,017 (81.4%) of Pacific school leavers attained NCEA Level 1 or above, unchanged from 2023. As shown in Figure 9, the NCEA Level 1 or above attainment rates for Pacific school leavers have been lower than the rate for all leavers since 2014. Between 2020 (peak attainment for Pacific school leavers) and 2024, the rate decreased by 6.0 percentage points. Between 2019 (the most recent year prior to Covid-19) and 2024, the rate decreased by 4.3 percentage points.

Figure 9: Pacific school leavers' attainment of NCEA Level 1 or above is unchanged from 2023



In 2024, 83.0% of Pacific female school leavers attained NCEA Level 1 or above compared to 79.8% of Pacific male school leavers, up 0.3 percentage points for females and down 0.4 percentage points for males from 2023. The gap in NCEA Level 1 attainment rates between females and males decreased from 3.3 percentage points in 2020 to 2.5 percentage points in 2023 before widening again to 3.2 percentage points in 2024. As shown in Figure 10, the attainment rates for females were higher than the rates for males over the period from 2020-2024.

Figure 10: The gap in attainment between female and male Pacific school leavers with NCEA Level 1 or above is decreasing

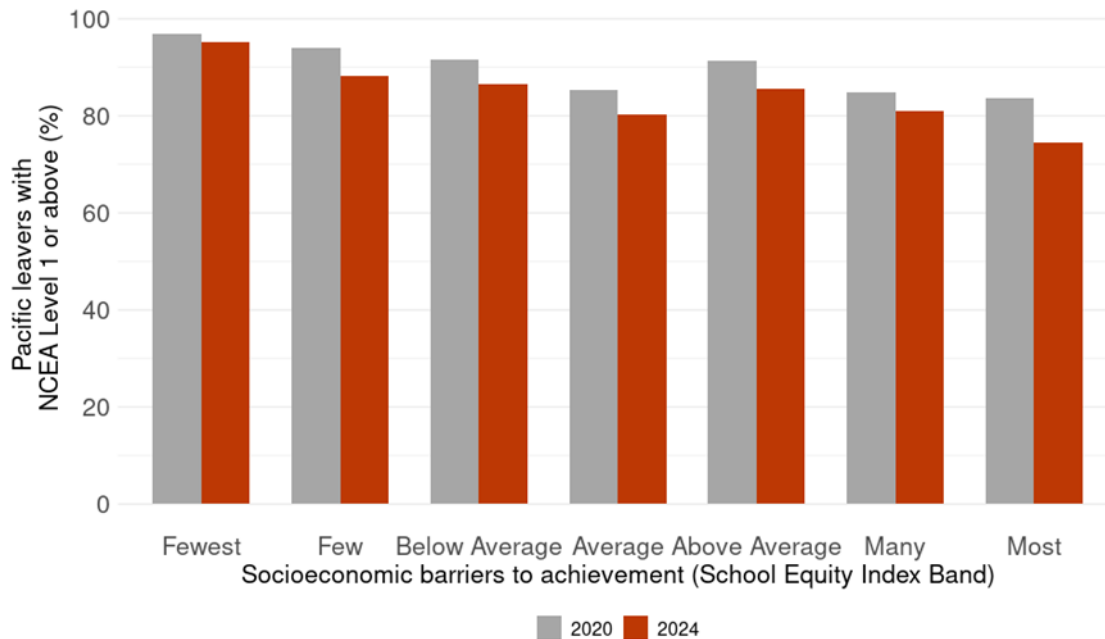


Pacific school leavers from schools where learners had fewer barriers to achievement were more likely to attain NCEA Level 1 or above. In 2024, 95.1% of Pacific leavers from schools with the fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 1 or above compared to 74.6% of Pacific leavers from schools where learners had the most barriers to achievement. Across all School Equity Index Bands, NCEA Level 1 or above attainment in 2024 was lower than in 2020 as shown in Figure 11.

While the five-year range from 2020-2024 shows that attainment of NCEA Level 1 or above declined from 2020-2024, Figure 11 also shows that these declines were highest for leavers in schools where learners had the most barriers to achievement. Between 2020 and 2024, the attainment rate for Pacific leavers from schools where learners had the most barriers decreased by 9.0 percentage points compared to 1.9 percentage points for Pacific leavers from schools where learners had the fewest barriers.



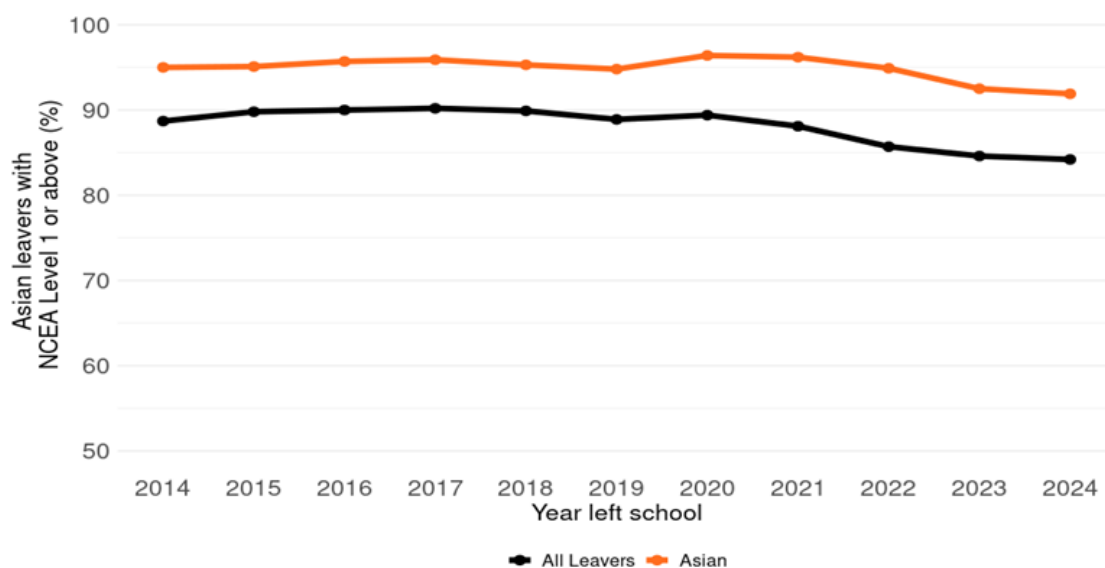
Figure 11: Pacific school leavers' attainment of NCEA Level 1 or above has decreased in all School Equity Index Bands between 2020 and 2024



Asian school leavers

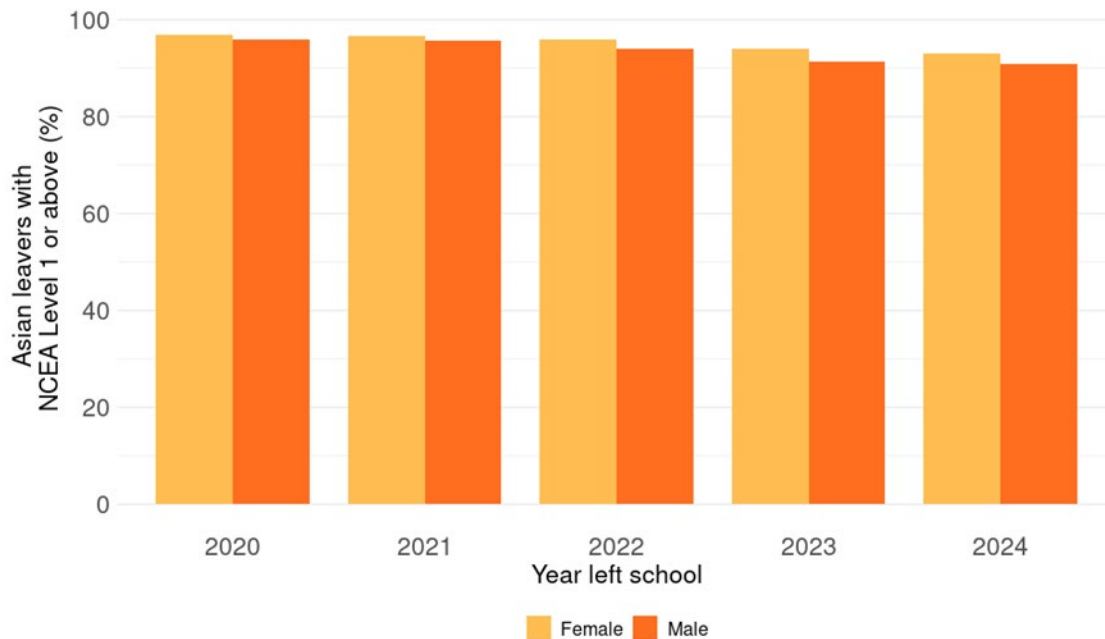
School leavers who identify with an Asian ethnicity had the highest attainment rate for NCEA Level 1 or above. The attainment rate for Asian leavers was stable with smaller fluctuations over the period from 2014-2024 as shown in Figure 12. In 2024, 91.9% of Asian school leavers attained NCEA Level 1 or above, down 0.6 percentage points from 2023. Between 2020 (peak attainment for Asian school leavers) and 2024, the rate decreased by 4.5 percentage points. Between 2019 (the most recent year prior to Covid-19) and 2024, the rate decreased by 2.9 percentage points.

Figure 12: A high proportion of Asian school leavers attained NCEA Level 1 or above



In 2024, 93.1% of Asian female school leavers attained NCEA Level 1 or above compared to 90.8% of Asian male school leavers. While these rates were high, they were the lowest rates for both Asian females and males since 2014. The gap in NCEA Level 1 or above attainment rates between Asian females and males increased, from 0.9 percentage points in 2020, to 2.5 percentage points in 2023 before narrowing again to 2.3 percentage points in 2024 (see Figure 13).

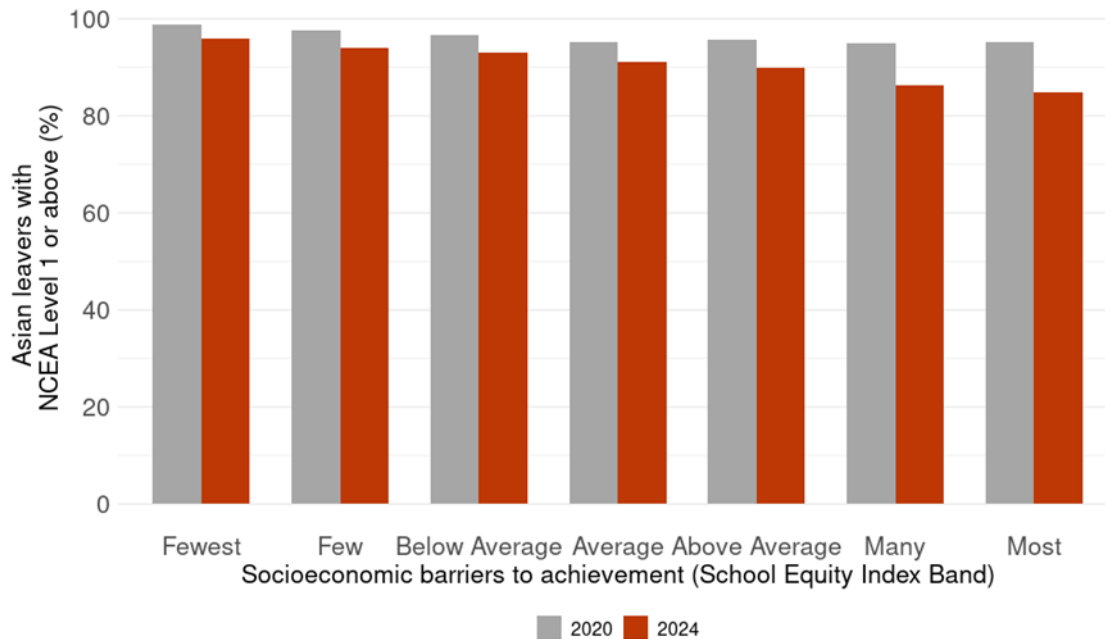
Figure 13: Asian female school leavers were more likely to attain NCEA Level 1 or above



The gradient effect for learners in schools where learners had fewer barriers to achievement was less evident for Asian learners as shown in Figure 14. In 2024, while a higher proportion of Asian school leavers from schools where learners had the fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 1 or above (96%) compared to Asian school leavers from schools in other bands, the attainment rates were higher than the national average for 2024 in all bands. School leavers from schools where learners had the most barriers to achievement had an attainment rate of 84.9% which was 0.7 percentage points higher than the national average rate for 2024.



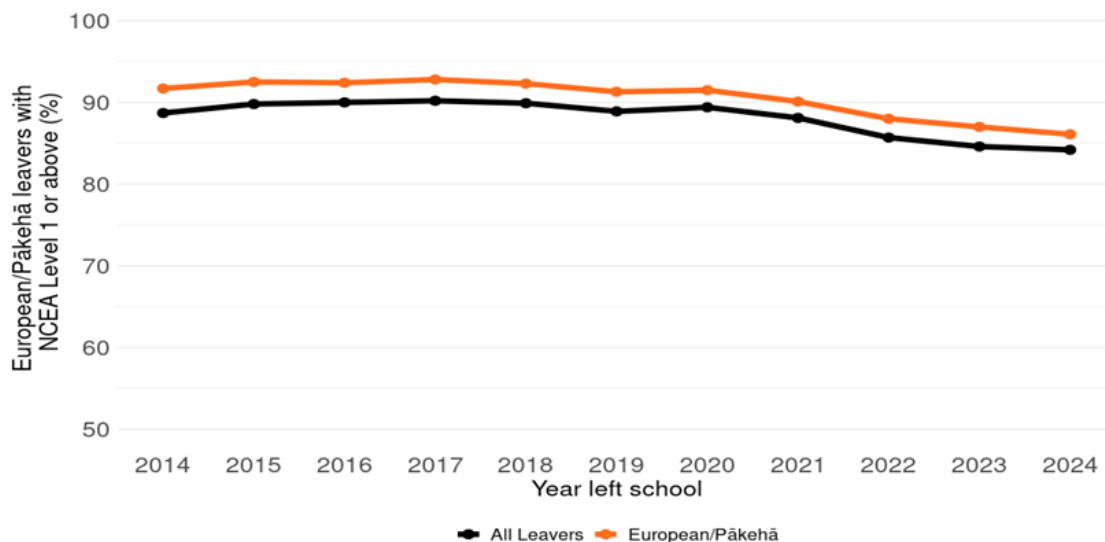
Figure 14: Figure 14: The proportion of Asian school leavers with NCEA Level 1 or above has decreased since 2020 in all School Equity Index Bands



European/Pākehā school leavers

In 2024, 86.1% of European/Pākehā school leavers attained NCEA Level 1 or above, down 1.0 percentage point from 2023. Between 2017 (peak attainment for European/Pākehā school leavers) and 2024, the rate decreased by 6.7 percentage points. Between 2019 (the most recent year prior to Covid-19) and 2024, the rate decreased by 5.3 percentage points (see Figure 15).

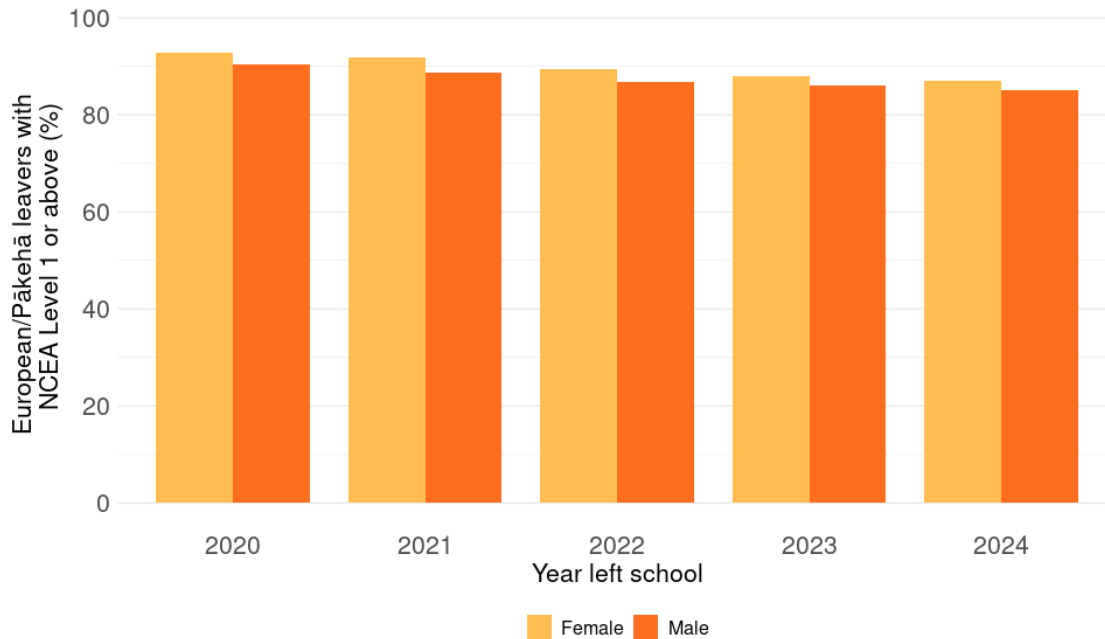
Figure 15: European/Pākehā school leavers' attainment of NCEA Level 1 or above decreased in 2024



In 2024, 86.9% of European/Pākehā female school leavers attained NCEA Level 1 or above compared to 85.2% of European/Pākehā male school leavers. The gap in NCEA Level 1 attainment rates between European/Pākehā females and males decreased from 2.6 percentage points in 2020, to 1.9 percentage points in 2023 and 1.7 percentage points in 2024 (Figure 16).

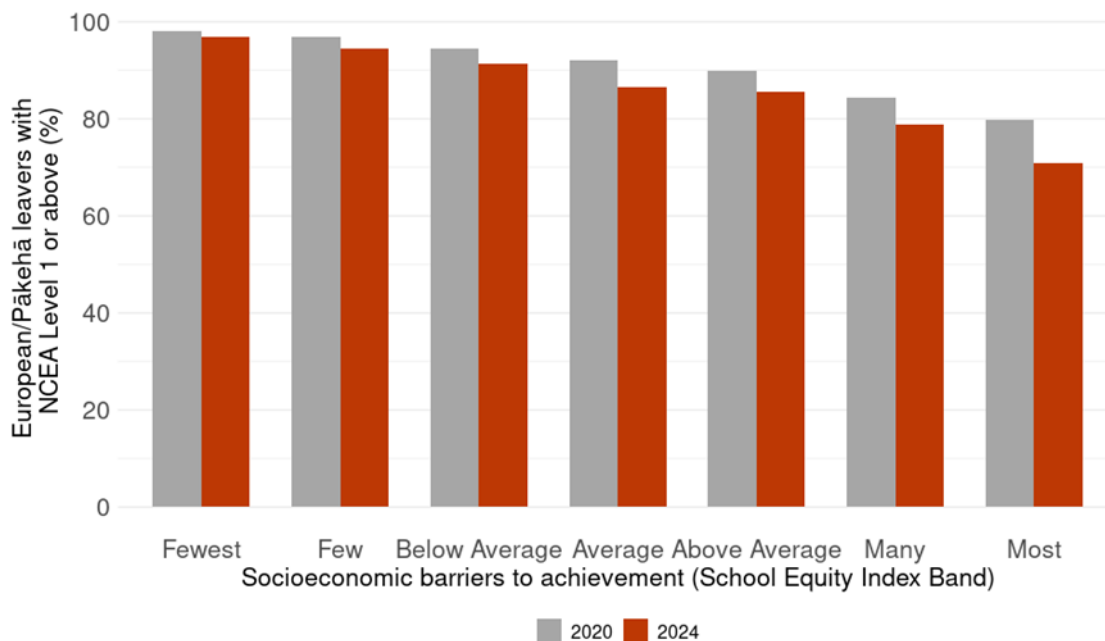


Figure 16: The gender gap for European/Pākehā school leavers with NCEA Level 1 or above has decreased



A higher proportion of European/Pākehā school leavers from schools where learners had fewer barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 1 or above as shown in Figure 17. In 2024, 96.9% of European/Pākehā from schools where learners had the fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 1 or above compared to 70.9% of European/Pākehā from schools where learners had the most barriers to achievement.

Figure 17: Since 2020, the proportion of European/Pākehā school leavers with NCEA Level 1 or above has decreased more in schools where learners had the most barriers to achievement



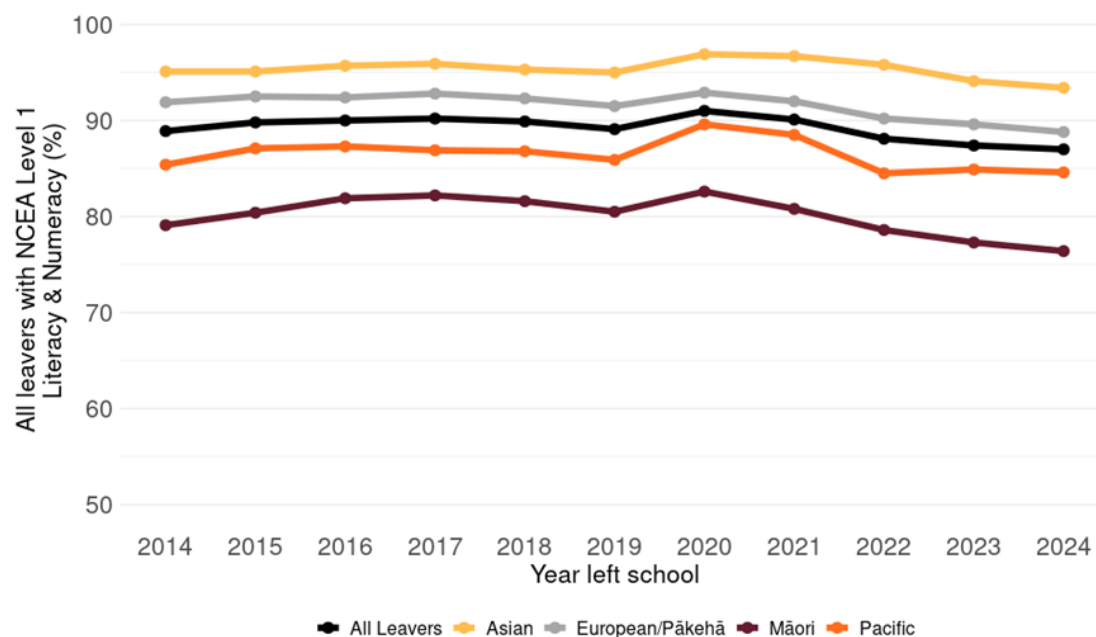
NCEA Level 1 literacy and numeracy requirements⁶

In 2024, 87% of school leavers met NCEA Level 1 literacy and numeracy requirements, 0.4 percentage points lower than in 2023, and a decrease of 1.9 percentage points since 2014.

Female school leavers (88.2%) met the requirements at a higher rate than male school leavers (85.8%). Since 2014, a higher proportion of female school leavers met literacy and numeracy requirements compared to their male peers.

In 2024, Asian school leavers had the highest proportion of school leavers meeting NCEA Level 1 literacy and numeracy requirements (93.4%), followed by European/Pākehā leavers (88.8%), Pacific leavers (84.6%) and Māori leavers (76.4%) as shown in Figure 18.

Figure 18: Compared to 2023, fewer school leavers met NCEA Level 1 literacy and numeracy requirements in 2024



School leavers of all ethnicities experienced a gradient of attainment of NCEA Level 1 literacy and numeracy requirements across all School Equity Index Bands in 2024 as shown in Figure 19. European/Pākehā and Māori school leavers' attainment of NCEA Level 1 literacy and numeracy have been most affected by socioeconomic factors since 2020.

In 2024, there was a 20.9 percentage point difference between Māori school leavers meeting literacy and numeracy requirements from schools where learners had the fewest barriers (95.6%) and Māori leavers from schools where learners had the most barriers (74.7%). Since 2020, this gap has increased by 1.7 percentage points.

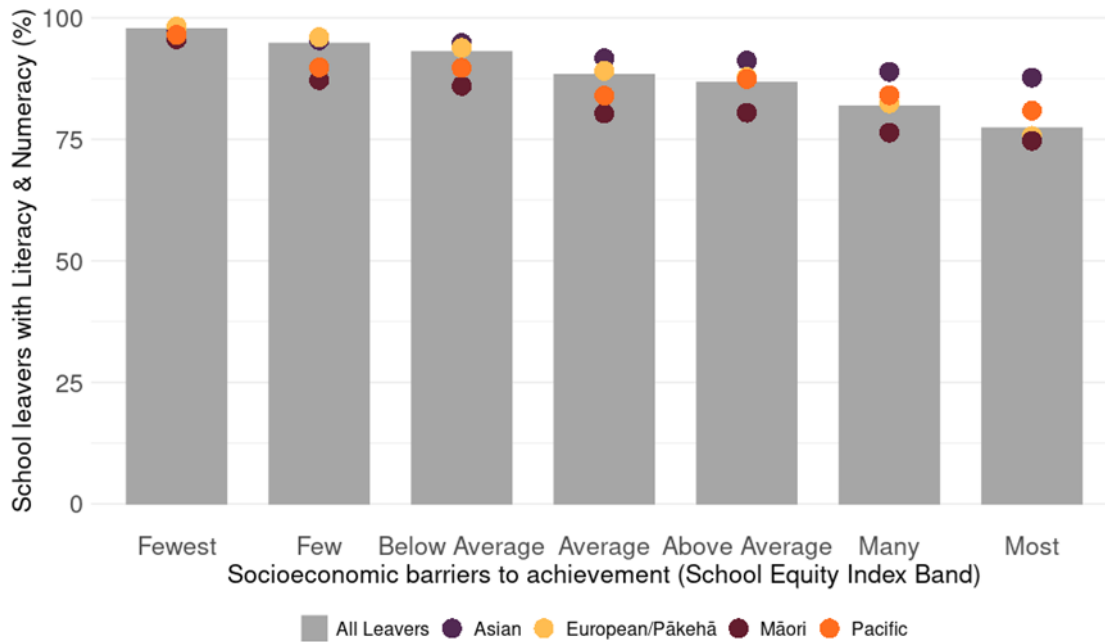
In 2024, there was a 22.5 percentage point difference between European/Pākehā leavers' literacy and numeracy attainment from schools where learners had the fewest barriers (98.2%) and European/Pākehā leavers from schools where learners had the most barriers (75.7%). Since 2020, this gap has increased by 7.8 percentage points.

⁶ Students cannot attain NCEA Level 1 unless they meet the NCEA literacy and literacy and numeracy requirements. For more information see [NCEA Changes for 2024 and 2025 - NZQA](#)



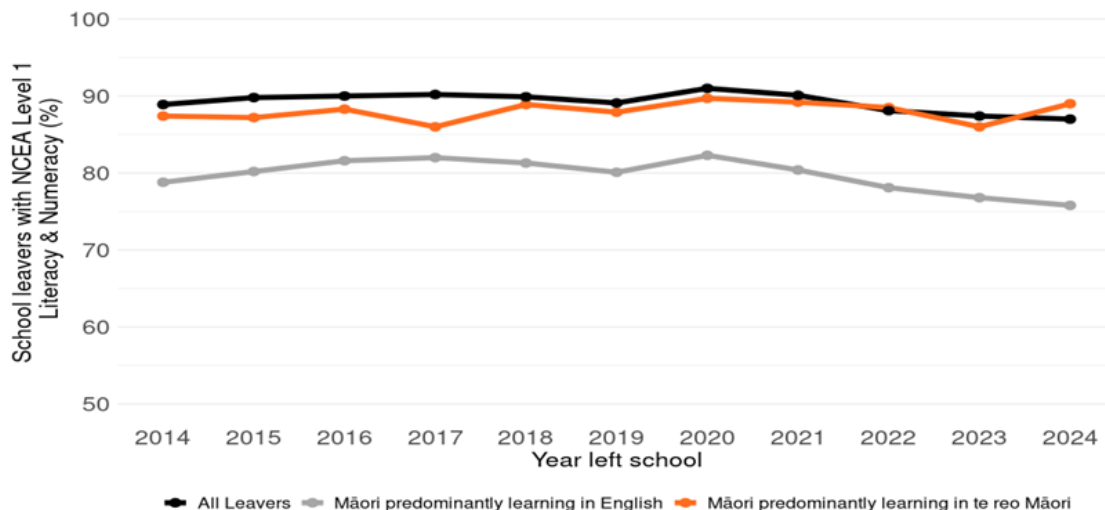
For Pacific and Asian school leavers, the difference in literacy and numeracy attainment in 2024 between leavers from schools where learners had the fewest barriers and leavers from schools where learners had the most barriers was 15.6 and 9.8 percentage points respectively. Since 2020, these gaps for Pacific and Asian leavers increased by 5.5 and 6.0 percentage points respectively.

Figure 19: School leavers of all ethnicities experienced a gradient of attainment of NCEA Level 1 literacy and numeracy requirements across all School Equity Index Bands



As shown in Figure 20, the attainment of NCEA level 1 literacy and numeracy requirements for Māori school leavers learning predominantly in te reo Māori was close to the attainment rate for all school leavers. In 2024, 89% of Māori school leavers predominantly learning in te reo Māori, and 75.8% of Māori school leavers learning predominantly in English met NCEA Level 1 literacy and numeracy requirements.

Figure 20: A higher proportion of Māori school leavers predominantly learning in te reo Māori met NCEA Level 1 literacy and numeracy requirements



About School Equity Index reporting

There are seven School Equity Index Bands, each containing approximately the same number of schools. Schools are placed into a band based on their School Equity Index Number. There are three School Equity Index Groups formed by collapsing the seven School Equity Index Bands as indicated in the following diagram. More information on this reporting method can be found on the Ministry's [Education Counts website](#)

Schooling Equity Index Number:



School Equity Index Band:

Fewest	Few	Below Average	Average	Above Average	Many	Most

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement

School Equity Index Group:

Fewer	Moderate	More

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement

Where to find out more

To obtain information about other forms of student disengagement consider indicators:

- [Tracked Year 11 cohort - Attainment timeframes for Level 2 certificate](#)
- [School leaver pathways](#)

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